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STUDY OF THE HUE MASSACRE

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HISTORY OF THE VIETNAM WAR ON MICROFILM

COMMUNIST POLITICAL EXECUTIONS AT HUE

IN THE 1968 TET OFFENSIVE

-- A DOCUMENTED REPORT

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INTRODUCTION

During their Tet (lunar new year) offensive of 1968, forces of the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) and the so-called South Vietnamese National Liberation Front (NLF), or Viet Cong, attacked the former imperial capital of Hue and occupied portions of the city for 26 days before being driven out by Republic of Viet-Nam and American troops and marines.

In the Battle of Hue, January 31 - February 25, 1968, and in the week thereafter as the Communist forces retreated from the city, more than 4,000 South Vietnamese civilians in and around the City of Hue lost their lives.

About 1,200 of these deaths (944 in Hue and 270 in the suburban and outlying areas) were battle casualties, resulting from injuries or wounds received during bombardments and exchanges of fire between the opposing forces or from Communist sniper fire while trying to escape.

But a total of 2,786 of these civilian victims were executed for political or psychological reasons or reasons of expediency while held captive by Viet Cong "special action" squads or military units.

In addition, NVA and NLF elements executed between 500 and 1,000 captive officers and soldiers of the Army of the

Republic of Viet-Nam (ARVN) during their occupation of and retreat from Hue. The number of South Vietnamese military personnel who died by execution at the hands of the Communist forces exceeds by far the number who died in combat during the struggle to liberate the city.^{1/}

Evidence of the systematic extermination of selected categories of citizens was clearly present during the period of the Communist occupation of Hue and its outlying districts. People's Revolutionary Party (PRP) proselyters, speaking in the name of the National Liberation Front, urged their followers to "track down (and) punish" what they termed "reactionaries, traitors, feudalists, spies, and puppet authorities."

Documents captured subsequent to the Battle of Hue and described later in the body of this report reveal that the "elimination" of key individuals and categories of persons was indicated in specific directives to NVA and NLF political cadre and troops prior to the attack on the city. On the list of persons to be arrested and "punished" were government officials, civil servants, policemen, "puppet soldiers," political party and trade union leaders, prominent intellectuals, teachers, including

^{1/} 384 South Vietnamese soldiers and marines died in the battle to free the city.

foreigners, and others identified by role or reputation as supporters of the Government of Viet-Nam. Their removal was depicted as an essential objective in the planned overthrow of the government of Hue and its replacement with a revolutionary government.

Eyewitness accounts of political executions of bound captives, both civilian and military, during the Communists' occupation of and withdrawal from Hue testify to the brutality with which the killings were carried out. The posture and condition of the bodies of some 3,000 victims discovered in mass graves in twenty-nine localities in Hue City and nearby communities in the past two years confirm this. Most of the victims -- men, women, and young people including school-age children -- had been bound at the wrists or elbows and shot or bludgeoned to death. In many instances, there is unmistakable evidence that victims, singly or in groups lashed to one another, were interred alive.

The fact that the Viet Cong were executing city and provincial officials, political party leaders, policemen, rural reconstruction workers, soldiers and others was common knowledge among the citizens of Hue during the Communists' occupation of that city.

Many Hue citizens were witnesses as Viet Cong executioners "punished" a relative who was on the Communist "black list" by shooting or beating him to death in the immediate vicinity of their homes. Some typical cases are described later in this report. Many deaths resulted from ten-minute drumhead "trials" of prominent citizens by so-called People's Courts, followed by immediate execution of the condemned.

But the dimensions of the Communist executions only became apparent following the expulsion of the NVA/NLF forces from the city on February 25, 1968. In the days that followed, mass graves containing the bodies of hundreds of South Vietnamese civilians and captive military personnel executed by the Communists were found in seventeen localities in and around Hue. More than 127 graves with the bodies of some 1,750 execution victims were discovered in Hue or within an eight-kilometer radius of the city in the six-week period from February 26 to April 8, 1968.

A year later, in March and April 1969, provincial authorities operating on information provided by local villagers, Viet Cong defectors and, in one notable instance, by an escaped captive who had watched from a nearby wood as his fellow prisoners were obliged to dig their own graves and then were shot,

uncovered forty-seven additional mass graves in the rice fields and sandy wastelands of the Huong Thuy and Phu Thu Districts between Hue and the nearby South China Sea. The bodies of 809 victims -- soldiers and civilians, including many women and children -- virtually all with hands or arms bound, were recovered from these graves.

In September 1969, information provided by Viet Cong defectors led local officials to a remote, jungle-covered creek in the mountains 14 kilometers south of Hue where the skeletal remains of some 500 persons taken from a Catholic church on the south side of Hue and from a neighboring Buddhist community in February 1968 were found. A Viet Cong unit had assembled the captives along the banks of the stream near its headwaters, shot them down with automatic weapons, and left the bodies where they fell.

Four hundred and twenty-eight of these victims were later identified, they included a number of high school and university students, civil servants, local homeguards, artisans and ordinary laborers.

The bodies of others, seized at the same time, were found in several mass graves along the route of march in the Nam Hoa District south of Hue in the summer of 1969.

In November 1969, several mass-grave trenches uncovered in the salt flats and sand dunes of the coastal strip near Luong Vien Village in the Phu Thu District approximately 16 kilometers east of Hue disclosed the bodies of 230 more execution victims.

Some 2,000 citizens of the Hue area who disappeared or who are known to have been seized by the Communist occupation forces during the 1968 Tet offensive are still missing and unaccounted for. A great number of these were taken away under circumstances similar to those in which many of the others whose bodies have since been recovered were taken. They were told they were to attend a three-day "political reeducation" meeting at an undisclosed spot and were then escorted away by Viet Cong soldiers or armed political cadre of the People's Revolutionary Party (the commanding element within the National Liberation Front) and not seen again.

The Government of the Republic of Viet-Nam fears that many of these people may also have been executed.

The Communist Front for the Liberation of South Viet-Nam has acknowledged that its forces and agents "annihilated" the citizens whose bodies were found in and around Hue, dismissing the victims as "hooligan lackeys who had owed blood debts to

(their) compatriots^{2/}

A report written by a command-level political officer of the People's Revolutionary Party in the Hue area immediately following the Battle of Hue lists a total of 2,826 administrative personnel, nationalist political party members, "tyrants," and policemen killed by the Communists in two suburban districts of Hue alone.^{3/}

Another report written by a member of the Hue City People's Revolutionary Party Central Committee in December 1968, summarizing the Party's accomplishments during the Tet attack on Hue, states that: "Thousands of tyrants (sic) were killed. Many reactionary factions and organizations were exterminated."^{4/}

The report that follows is based upon authenticated data from the files of the municipal and provincial police at Hue, the Health, and Social Welfare, Refugee Relief Service and other agencies of the City of Hue and Province of Thua Thien; interviews with witnesses, survivors, officials, relief workers (both private and public) and others who were in Hue and its

^{2/} See text of Hanoi Radio broadcast of April 27, 1969, Document A.

^{3/} See B.

^{4/} See C.

outlying districts during the Communist attack and retreat or who were present at the exhumation of victims from the mass graves; press accounts by journalists who were in Hue at the time the city was liberated from the Communist forces or who have visited there and talked with people since; personal recollections, notably the graphic accounts contained in the volume A Mourning Turban for Hue, published in December 1969 by the South Vietnamese author and poetess Nha Ca; ^{5/} pronouncements and writings by officials of the Government of Viet-Nam, political party leaders, and private citizens regarding the Tet Mau Than events at Hue; Government of Viet-Nam documents, reports and press releases; enemy broadcasts by Hanoi Radio and the clandestine "Liberation Radio" of the National Liberation Front; and documents of the North Vietnamese Army, National Liberation Front, and People's Revolutionary Party which have fallen into the hands of South Vietnamese and allied forces since the Communist Tet offensive of 1968.

The purpose of this report is to provide readers in the Republic of Viet-Nam and other countries with a documented,

^{5/} Nha Ca, Giai Khan So Cho Hue (A Mourning Turban for Hue), Saigon: Thuong Yeu Publishers, 1969, 523 pp. This volume has brought home to millions of South Vietnamese readers the violence, tragedy, pathos, and terror of the events at Hue and the nature of the "liberation" by the Communist forces.

factual account of the execution of captive soldiers and civilians by Viet Cong forces in and around Hue during the 1968 Tet offensive and to describe the context in which these killings took place.

Only through a clear understanding of the events at Hue during this one moment of history in which the North Vietnamese Army and the forces of the National Liberation Front obtained a fleeting, if transitory, control over a South Vietnamese city can readers assess realistically the consequences of Communist authority.

THE TET 1968 COMMUNIST OFFENSIVE

At the end of January 1968, during the annual festivities celebrating Tet, the lunar new year, forces of the Democratic Republic of Viet-Nam (North Viet-Nam) and the South Vietnamese National Liberation Front (Viet Cong) launched a major offensive throughout the Republic of Viet-Nam. The offensive was in direct violation of a seven-day cease-fire for the Tet holidays proclaimed by the Hanoi government and the National Liberation Front Radio more than two months before and implemented plans mapped out in Communist Party directives as much as six months before.

The Communist forces mounted ground attacks supported by rockets, mortars, automatic weapons, and demolition (sapper) squads against 35 of South Viet-Nam's major population centers, including four of the nation's largest cities (Saigon, Danang, Hue, and Can Tho) and 26 provincial capitals, within a six-day period (January 29 - February 3). During the same period and the week thereafter, while continuing their sniper fire, demolitions, armed propaganda, and terrorist acts in a number of these cities, the Communist forces directed rocket and mortar barrages and harassing fire at no fewer than 85 other communities, including district capitals, throughout the country.

These attacks were followed by a "second wave," beginning on February 17 and continuing through the month of March, in which the Communist forces assaulted and re-assaulted communities throughout South Viet-Nam. The attacking forces were consistently repulsed, although casualties were high both among the attackers and the defenders, particularly among the civilian population. ^{8/} In no instance -- with the exception of Hue -- did the attacking forces succeed in occupying any community for more than 48 hours.

Hue was a different story. Taking advantage of the Tet holiday cease-fire and the reduced strength of Republic of Viet-Nam defense forces (many of our troops having been granted furloughs in order to spend the traditional holiday period with their families), elements of two North Vietnamese Army regiments infiltrated this big Central Vietnamese city in the northern quarter of the Republic during the night of January 30-31 and launched a full-scale attack. They were supported by rocket and mortar barrages launched from the hills to the

^{6/} The Joint General Staff, Republic of Viet-Nam Armed Forces, has published the following figures for the period February-March 1968:

	<u>Killed</u>	<u>Wounded</u>	<u>Captured or Missing in Action</u>	<u>Homeless</u>
VC/NVA (by body count)	58,373	Unknown	9,461	
RVN military personnel	4,954	15,097	926	
Allied Military (mainly US)	4,124	19,285	604	
RVN civilians (approx.)	14,300	24,000	(No est.)	627,000

west which started fires all across the city.

By dawn of January 31, the Communist forces had stormed and infiltrated the walled Citadel in the center of Hue and were meeting fierce resistance from the undermanned headquarters garrison of the 1st ARVN Infantry Division. By dawn of the second day (February 1) the Communist forces had consolidated their hold on all but a small part of the Citadel and their political cadre and military units operated freely in all three administrative districts of the city.

The enemy remained in Hue for twenty-six days, from January 31 to February 25, before the last battered remnants of his forces withdrew from the southern corner of the Citadel where they had held out. During those twenty-six days in which the NVA and NLF forces occupied all or parts of the city:

1,214 civilians (944 in Hue and 270 in its suburbans) were battle casualties, killed as a direct result of the battle for the city.

1,260 civilians were treated for injuries or wounds at local clinics and hospitals, and an unknown number of others received local medical assistance or treated themselves and did not report their wounds.

384 South Vietnamese and 148 American soldiers and marines were killed in action, defending and liberating the city.

1,830 South Vietnamese and American soldiers and marines were wounded.

2,736 South Vietnamese and 23 foreign civilians (American, French, German, Korean, and Chinese) are confirmed as having been executed by the Communist forces.

Some 5,800 citizens disappeared, of whom the executed bodies of more than 3,000 (civilians and soldiers) have been recovered.

57,805 citizens were rendered homeless.

4,456 civilian houses were totally destroyed, 3,360 were damaged more than fifty percent and 2,757 damaged less than fifty percent.

Eighty percent of the business district was wrecked or badly damaged.

What were the objectives of the North Vietnamese People's Army and the forces of the National Liberation Front in launching this destructive assault on the City of Hue?

What was their rationale for the deliberate killing of these defenseless civilians and captive soldiers?

To understand this, it is necessary first to know something of the nature of Hue as a military target, its symbolism for the Vietnamese people, and the character and mood of its populace.

Then it is necessary to examine the mood and motivation of the enemy forces and the specific missions and objectives spelled out for them in meticulous detail by the political leadership of the North Vietnamese Army and the National Liberation Front in the days preceding the Communist assault.

HUE AS A STRATEGIC AND PSYCHOLOGICAL TARGET

As a strategic target, the City of Hue has unmistakable value for the enemy. The city lies athwart both National Highway 1 and the wide-gauge railroad which once linked Saigon in the South with Hanoi in the North. Lying some 85 kilometers southeast of the Demilitarized Zone (DMZ) and the 17th parallel, dividing Viet-Nam, it is the terminus of Highway 547 which winds across the rugged mountains to the south and west to the A Shau Valley, a major infiltration route for the Northern Communist divisions. Highway 1 also links at Dong Ha with Highway 9 which leads on westward past Khe Sanh to Laos and another sector of the so-called Ho Chi Minh invasion route coming down from the north.

To the southeast of Hue, 103 kilometers, is Da Nang, South Viet-Nam's second largest city and a major air, navy, marine and logistical base.

Hue City spreads out along both sides of one of South Viet-Nam's principal outlets to the sea -- the Song Huong, or Perfume River -- which has sufficient depth to accommodate coastal vessels of medium tonnage and ready access to the South China Sea at the Coast Guard station and fishing port of Lai An some 16 kilometers downstream.

The city is dominated by the Citadel. This formidable structure, constructed for the Emperor Gia Long, founder of the Nguyen Hue dynasty, at the beginning of the last century, lies on the north bank of the river and covers an area of some six square kilometers, comprising one of Hue's three major administrative districts. An almost perfect square, it is bounded by the Perfume River on the southeast, the Dong Ba River on the northeast, the Dao Cua Han River on the northwest, and the Ko Van River on the southwest. It is further protected by an inner moat which runs around perhaps seventy-five percent of the total area, along the great outer walls.

The Citadel's walls are constructed in a dragon tooth configuration, varying from 17 meters to as much as seventy-five meters in thickness, and five-to-seven meters in height. The outer and inner sides of these walls are built of one-meter-thick stone. In between there is dirt fill and solid brick and mortar. The walls are latticed with passageways constructed so as to permit rapid communication and the protected storage of munitions and supplies. There are only eight access gates to the entire area.

Some 40,000 of Hue's total population of 140,000-150,000 live and work inside this walled or inner city. The Citadel also

contains the former Imperial Palace, the Museum of the City's art treasures, the headquarters command of the 1st Infantry Division of the Army of the Republic of Viet-Nam (ARVN), an airstrip, major market areas, and a number of churches, pagodas, orphanages, schools, public health stations and hospitals, as well as some 8,000 homes.

From the walls of the Citadel, the Communist guns would control the main highway and railroad bridges crossing the Perfume River from the south, the several other bridges linking the Inner City to other areas of the city to the north, east and west, and traffic along the waterways which they span. Moreover, the flat paddy lands surrounding the city would give them a free field of fire against South Vietnamese and American forces coming to the relief of the city.

In sum, control of Hue by the Communists meant control of waterways, highways, a railroad, and river craft, a virtually impregnable fortress area for their defense, an extended capability of harassment against counterattacking troops, a sizable civilian labor force to be coerced into serving their needs, and an area of operation providing both sustenance (fish and rice) and a network of small streams and byways for logistical support and resupply.

Such was Hue as a military objective. But Hue as a political and psychological objective was far more significant to the forces of the Northern Communist regime at Hanoi and the so-called National Liberation Front. There is no other city in Viet-Nam that has the special meaning for our people that this city has. A passageway between the north and the south and a seat of government since ancient times, the area is identified with the centuries-long struggle of our Vietnamese forebears to deliver themselves from Chinese rule. In more recent times our people -- both in the north and in the south -- have venerated this city as a center of culture and learning and the repository of our civilization, culture, and beliefs.

To the Vietnamese people, Hue is the personification of the family loyalty and ancestor reverence which are the essence and anchor of every Vietnamese man, woman and child. With its tombs of former emperors, its broad tree-lined avenues, its churches and temples, its great Citadel, and its impressive setting along the banks of a romantic river with sweet-scented forests covering the hills nearby, Hue is loved by the Vietnamese people and is a favorite spot for tourists and honeymooners. It is both the national symbol of our past and the touchstone of our emotions as a people --

a place redolent of memories and the subject of countless love stories, romantic songs and verses, and heroic legends.

Possession of this strategic and symbolic city in the very heart of Viet-Nam, even if only for a brief period, could not fail to have a psychological impact and damage the South Vietnamese people's will to resist, it was reckoned by the Communist planners.

In the weeks preceding their attack on Hue, Viet Cong agents mounted a widespread whispering campaign in Thua Thien Province, of which Hue is the capital, and Quang Tri Province to the effect that the Government of Viet-Nam was preparing to cede these two northernmost provinces to North Viet-Nam as a buffer zone as a concession to end the war. These rumors were categorically refuted by the government and denounced in speeches by President Thieu in Quang Tri, Thua Thien, and Hue only four days before Tet. 7/

7/ On Friday, January 26, 1968, the President flew by helicopter to ARVN outposts near the DMZ in Quang Tri Province and northern Thua Thien, dedicated the cornerstone of a proposed National Youth Center at the foot of the Trang Tien Bridge in the center of Hue, and attended ceremonies honoring local leaders and civil service workers at a New Life refugee hamlet several kilometers west of Hue. In speeches at each of these places, he characterized these rumors as "rubbish" and "Viet Cong psychological warfare tricks" designed to undermine confidence in the central government at Saigon, confuse the people, and lower public morale. He assured the people that the Government of the Republic of Viet-Nam had no secret dealings with the enemy and certainly had no intention of ceding "one square meter" of the northern provinces to the Communists.

To understand what happened in Hue, it is necessary to know something of the significance of the holiday season the Vietnamese people were celebrating when the attacks began. Tet Nguyen Dan, or Lunar New Year, is a time of happiness and homecoming for our people, of families coming together to feast and rejoice, to honor the sacred memories of our dead and our ancestors, to exchange gifts to acquit ourselves of debts and grievances, to lift up our spirits with the arrival of spring and the renewal of life. It is a time for the children, for setting off strings of firecrackers and tossing money into the dragon's mouth, the time for merriment and good cheer. It is a time of thanksgiving, good feelings, high hopes, and families happily reunited.

Work usually stops for at least three days during the Tet time. Many thousands of visitors come to Hue each year at this time to visit relatives and enjoy the rich atmosphere of this beautiful city with its legendary River of Perfumes and its reminders of our national heritage.

Many were visiting there on the first night of Tet Mau Than, the Year of the Monkey (January 30, 1968). The city of Hue was packed with people -- with sons and daughters home from distant parts of the Republic to spend their holidays, with government officials, soldiers and sailors and airmen on furlough, and with

students and teachers relaxing on vacation. For the moment, the war was almost forgotten. Undoubtedly many people trusted the Communists' announcement of a complete cease-fire for seven full days during Tet. 8/

8/ On 18 November 1967, in a 7:30 a.m. broadcast, the Viet Cong clandestine Liberation Radio carried under a Hanoi dateline the text of an order issued by the command of the People's Liberation Armed Forces which was described as being "in strict implementation of the instruction of the Presidium of the Central Committee of the South Viet-Nam National Front for Liberation." The order, which was later twice broadcast by Hanoi Radio in its International Service in English at 2:03 p.m. and 2:26 p.m. the same day, stated that all National Liberation Front main force, regional, local force, and guerrilla units would "suspend their military attacks for three days on the occasion of Christmas [dates and hours given] ... for three days on the occasion of Tet [the Lunar New Year Festival], from 12:00 o'clock midnight 27 January 1968 Indo-China time -- or 1:00 a.m. 27 January 1968 Saigon time ... to 12:00 o'clock midnight 3 February 1968...."

The broadcast announcements stated that the cease-fire order was being given: "to protect the people so that they can enjoy the Tet in security and happiness and to create facilities for soldiers and personnel of the Saigon puppet (sic) administration... to rejoin their families, invoke the memories of their forebears, and visit their relatives." The Communist forces violated this order numerous times. The massive assaults on South Vietnamese cities during the announced seven-day cease-fire for Tet 1968 began on 29 January, two days after it was supposedly in effect, with rocket and mortar attacks on a number of towns and an attempt to seize the important coastal city of Nha Trang. They culminated with the full-scale Communist offensive against Saigon, Hue, and more than thirty other South Vietnamese population centers in the night of 30-31 January -- exactly midway in the Communist-announced truce period.

Then the enemy struck. In the night, as the city slept, the Viet Cong and North Vietnamese political agents and demolition squads which had infiltrated the city amid the holiday confusion emerged from their hiding places. They collected their weapons, munitions and explosives from the secret caches where they had been hidden and joined the invading North Vietnamese battalions which were moving into Hue under cover of the darkness.

NVA/NLF ASSAULT ON HUE

The Communists prepared elaborately for their Tet attack on Hue. In readying for their so-called Winter-Spring Offensive, the North Vietnamese Army had massed elements of five divisions in the two northernmost provinces of South Vietnam -- Quang Tri and Thua Thien. These were supplemented by more than a dozen NLF (Viet Cong) maneuver battalions, in addition to various Viet Cong guerrilla bands, demolition companies, and local force units.

Papers captured by Republic of Viet-Nam forces during the Battle of Hue showed that the military commanders of the NVA and National Liberation Front had mapped out their final plan of attack against the old imperial city twenty days in advance of the attack. The plans were extensive, comprehensive, and specific. They indicated the exact routes of approach and rendezvous points for the operational units, the targets to be attacked by each, the demolition units to be infiltrated into the city during the Tet festivities, the locations and inventories of uniform and weapon caches, the securing of essential transportation facilities and resupply and reinforcement routes, the drafting of local labor

and combat recruits, and contingency plans for operations against counterattacking Republic of Viet-Nam forces.

They included such details as instructions for passing through drainage ducts and climbing the vines of a particular banyan tree in order to scale the walls of the Citadel and penetrate the inner city, and the number of explosive charges and quantity of dog poison to be issued to members of demolition squads.

The Communist forces struck after midnight on the night of January 30-31, 1968, moving eight battalions, comprising elements of three regiments, into the city.

The invading North Vietnamese Army battalions and the National Liberation Front forces launched their attack at 2:30 a.m. on January 31 with a rocket and mortar barrage. Hundreds of rounds of 107 and 122 millimeter rockets and 82 millimeter heavy mortars hit the Command Headquarters of the ARVN First Infantry Division and the Dong Ba military training center inside the Citadel. The headquarters of the Thua Thien Province military sector and the United States Military Assistance Command (MACV) in the District III residential section on the south side of the river were also targets.

Many of the rockets and mortars went astray, setting buildings and houses ablaze throughout the city and causing numerous civilian

casualties.

Under cover of this artillery assault, VC and NVA infantry and sapper forces that had infiltrated along the northwestern wall of the Citadel stormed the An Hoa Gate and entered the walled city. Another assault group stormed the Chanh Tay Gate in the southwest wall. These forces were joined by other elements which had scaled the walls elsewhere or come out of hiding after penetrating the Citadel earlier during the Tet festivities and now launched full-scale assaults against the Tay Loc airfield, the ARVN First Infantry Division headquarters area, and the fortified Mang Ca defense post in the northern corner of the Citadel. They occupied the former imperial palace, which lies inside the southeast wall of the Citadel, and converted it to a command post.

The Communist forces seized all bridges within the city, commandeered civilian vehicles, sampans, and junks, and spread out through all three districts of the city. They also launched attacks against An Hoa Village and the Huong Tra District town northwest of Hue, blocked off Highway 1 and other roads into the city, and occupied suburban villages on all sides of Hue.

Resistance mounted by elements of the ARVN 1st Infantry Division's all-volunteer Hac Bao (Black Panther) Company and other South Vietnamese infantrymen, marines and police succeeded

in thwarting the Communists' attempts to seize the airfield and the 1st Infantry Division headquarters command.

But by the end of the first day, except for these isolated sectors, the Communist forces possessed the city of Hue. An heroic unit of ARVN infantrymen that had held out atop the southeast wall of the Citadel at the great terraced height known as the "King's Knight," which guards the entrance to the Palace and overlooks the broad Perfume River, was wiped out by the enemy forces inside the Citadel during the night of January 31.

At dawn on Thursday, February 1, 1968, the Communists ran up the yellow-starred red and blue flag of the National Liberation Front on the Citadel wall. Viet Cong political agents and armed bands circulated freely in all sections of the city and its suburbs.

COMMUNIST MISSIONS AND OBJECTIVES

As attested in numerous captured enemy documents and in accounts by NVA and NLF (Viet Cong) prisoners and defectors since the Battle of Hue, the Communist forces had three major missions in their attack on the city. These missions, assigned by the Central Military Affairs Committee of the Dang Lao Dong Viet Nam (North Vietnamese Communist Party) and its southern component, the People's Revolutionary Party (PRP), for the so-called Tri-Thien-Hue Military Region, were to:

(1) Conduct a general attack and uprising to destroy the South Vietnamese troops and authorities in Hue.

(2) Overthrow the Republic of Viet-Nam's governmental apparatus in the City of Hue and Province of Thua Thien "through the revolutionary force of the people" and establish a revolutionary administration.

(3) Continue to pursue and counterattack Republic of Viet-Nam and Allied forces and authorities in order to protect "the revolutionary authorities" and the Communist area of activities.

These general missions and objectives for the attack on Hue were elaborated and spelled out in meticulous detail for the NLF/PRP

political cadres operating as special action units or within military elements in a comprehensive directive issued by the Tri-Thien-Hue Political Directorate on January 26, 1968 -- four days before the attack. ^{9/}

Operating in close support of the regular military and guerrilla elements, the political cadres were to:

-- destroy and disorganize the Republic of Viet-Nam's (RVN) administrative machinery "from province and district levels to the city wards, streets, and wharves;"

-- motivate the people of Hue to take up arms, pursue the enemy, seize power, and establish a revolutionary government;

-- motivate recruit local citizens for military and "security forces ... transportation and supply activities, and to serve wounded soldiers;"

-- "pursue to the end (and) punish" spies, reactionaries, and "tyrants" -- i.e., government administrators, civil servants, police, and others employed by or notable adherents of the Republic of Viet-Nam; and

-- "maintain order and security in the city" -- i.e., control the population.

This directive sets out "Fundamental Guidelines" for the

^{9/} Document D.

political agents: "Coordinate military, political, and troop proselyting activities. Emphasis should be placed on our strength for ... gaining control of the people. Coordinate activities between overt and covert forces .. make preparations for a long-range struggle ... unremittingly attack the enemy. Stay close to the working class people to attack and destroy the enemy and rapidly strengthen our forces."

It then sets out specific wards with boundaries and street names established within each, with areas of operation, designation of cell leaders, and specific missions to be carried out. These detailed neighborhood assignments of "missions" have a grim monotony. Target Area 1, under the Communist operational plan, for example, was the Phu Ninh Ward, a residential section on the south side of the river containing the Central Hospital, the University of Hue, teachers' and students' quarters, the headquarters of the provincial government, the offices of various provincial and municipal services, and the residences of thousands of civil servants, professional people, and workers at various levels of the economic scale. The specific mission assigned to the cells operating in Area 1 are quoted in part as follows:

Annihilate all spies, reactionaries, and foreign teachers (such as Americans or Germans) in the area.

Break open prisons. Investigate and classify cadre, soldiers and receptive civilians imprisoned by the enemy.

Search for tyrants and reactionaries who are receiving medical treatment in hospitals

Encircle the area around Binh Linh School and prevent tyrants from going in or out.

.....

Motivate workers, civil servants, students, and pupils to cooperate with the armed force to annihilate the enemy and support our struggle.

In Target Area 2, the Phu Vinh Ward, a predominantly Buddhist neighborhood west of Phu Ninh:

Annihilate the enemy in the area....

Transform workers into a political force....

Rally the Buddhist force to advance the isolation of reactionaries who exploit the Catholics of Phu Cam.

In Target Area 3, "the wharves along the An Cuu River and from Truong Sung to the Kho Ren Bridge:"

Search for and pursue spies, tyrants, and reactionaries hiding near the wharf....

Motivate the people in the areas along the River to annihilate the enemy.

.....

Encourage the people to engage in our security activities on the River.

In Target Area 4, including the predominantly Catholic district of Phu Cam and the neighboring Binh An, Truong Giang, Truong Cuu and An Lang sections:

Search for and pursue spies and reactionaries within the area.

Destroy the power and influence of reactionary ringleaders who exploit the Catholics in Phu Cam and isolate them.

Motivate the proletarians among the religious people and mobilize the people to search for and detect the enemy so as to help the war.

Throughout this Party directive, which runs to more than 3,500 words and covers the operations in only one of the City's three administrative districts, there is an ominous repetition of the injunction to "annihilate," to "track down," to "search out" and to "punish" individuals who are loosely identified as spies, lackeys, reactionaries, scoundrels, tyrants, or, simply "the enemy."

This is virtually a blank cheque for execution.

The planned extermination of civilians for political reasons is so well understood within the context of this general order that in setting forth the functional tasks and leadership structure of the various cells, the murder role of one unit is mentioned

within parentheses:

"Area 1, Cell 3: (Annihilation of tyrants and the elimination of traitors). It is directed by Comrade Thai Anh, Armed Reconnaissance Command Cadre, with the assistance of a number of troops. In addition to this cell, there is a special action unit commanded by Comrade Thich."

An extensive section of the directive is devoted to a heading entitled: "SOLUTION FOR A NUMBER OF SPECIFIC MATTERS." The initial subsection under this heading deals with the capture and handling of prisoners, including the Province Chief and his Deputy, ARVN and American officers and civilian personnel, and local government authorities. It includes the following passage:

... If possible, by 1200 hours of the first day, we should succeed in capturing many of them or force them to surrender. We should record their voice and play it over a loud-speaker to persuade their subordinates to surrender. Also, steps should be taken to evacuate them outside the city.

If we should have to fight until the evening of the first day ... they should be evacuated outside the city immediately.

In case we have to fight for several days, we must force them to write a statement of surrender, to denounce the U.S. imperialists' crimes, and to reveal their friends before we kill them on the spot. This is only applied in case we cannot overcome difficulties. We must

not take this opportunity to kill them indiscriminately.

The second subsection under these "Solutions for Specific Matters" covers "Measures to take against cruel tyrants, reactionary elements and their allies:"

We must concentrate and imprison them in an area. Ringleaders must be imprisoned separately. When it is convenient, we should move them out of town to exploit and punish them.

Subsection 3 states that "directors, assistant directors, service chiefs, service assistant chiefs, or hard core personnel working for the American, Puppet, and satellite agencies (sic)" must be captured. But "government employees who work for the enemy in order to make a living should be indoctrinated and allowed to serve in the Revolution."

Under the heading "Religion," there was an ominous indication of things to come. This section is quoted in full:

a. Catholic: We must encircle churches and schools. In case the enemy hides in the church, we must pursue him and capture him. Priests and vicars who protect and conceal the enemy should be arrested immediately.

We must explain to the people our reasons, at the same time force them to give us their weapons. We should carefully judge criminals (sic) in order to determine their punishment (death or imprisonment).

b. Buddhist: We must employ every means to convince the people as well as Buddhist monks and nuns to join us.

In short, as recalled in a massive report prepared for the Hue City Party Committee on the Party's accomplishments during 1968, ^{10/} the mission assigned by higher echelons prior to the assault on this key city of Central Viet-Nam was "to combine Offensive Actions and Uprisings to occupy Hue." The mission was to "destroy and wear down" government and allied military forces and administrative units; seize and interdict all avenues of communication; "motivate the masses to arm themselves and rise up to destroy (government) administrative agencies of all levels, from province level down to village, hamlet, and even quarter levels, to bring under complete liberation (sic) the surrounding rural areas and the city and to set up revolutionary control organs."

^{10/} Document C.

EXECUTION OF POLITICAL PRISONERS

The North Vietnamese Army and the "National Liberation Front" failed to achieve their objectives at Hue as they failed in the more than thirty other South Vietnamese cities they attempted to invade during the Tet holiday season of 1968. There was no popular uprising in response to their importunings and threats. City and provincial administrative agencies, though disrupted, were not destroyed. Communications were soon restored by counterattacking ARVN and U.S. forces. And the Revolutionary Government that was the key objective of the Communist assault did not emerge as a political reality, despite proclamations broadcast by Hanoi and the Liberation Radio in its name. ^{11/}

But while failing in their political objectives at Hue, the agents of the National Liberation Front and their military auxiliaries carried out faithfully the program of "revolutionary violence" contained in their pre-attack directives.

^{11/} At 5:30 p.m., Saigon time, on February 1, 1968, the day after the Communists' seizure of Hue, Radio Hanoi, citing the Liberation Press Agency, broadcast a statement said to have been issued by the Peaceful, Democratic, National Alliance Front of Hue City. The statement called on "all groups and all forces of patriotic people, youths, women, college students, and high school students in Hue city ... to rise up to conduct an armed uprising..."

Within hours of their occupation of the city, Communist Party political cadre armed with "black lists" of names of "suspect persons" were calling at houses in all three districts of Hue and making arrests. Some on these lists were taken to temporary Party headquarters locations, given a brief trial on charges of being "an enemy of the people," convicted, and shot.^{12/} Others were summarily executed in or near their homes. Hue's popular Deputy Mayor Tran Dinh Phuong was among these early victims. He was executed in front of his own house and his body left lying for eight days before it could be recovered for burial.

Leading civil servants, police officials, military officers and some non-commissioned officers, nationalist political party

^{12/} The Vietnamese woman writer Nha Ca, who was in Hue at the time of the Communist occupation, writes in her book A Mourning Turban for Hue, cited earlier in the Introduction: "Right in the afternoon of the third day of Tet [second day of the Communist occupation of the city] people in some areas witnessed the trials in public. Some local personalities were arrested on charges of collaborating with the Americans and their puppet regime (sic). They were led into a school where young men and women were assembled. The familiar individuals who worked for the VC underground were the most competent to relate the crimes of the accused. Sentences were hastily made. The accused were led away and that very evening, stories were heard about their executions. People had not yet collected their wits after their ordeals through the firing on Tet night and the sight of corpses littering the streets the following morning and now they started to worry about their fate because of the searches, trials and executions by the Liberation Army." (Page 145.)

leaders, judges, public prosecutors, community leaders, and persons working for American agencies were among the principal targets.

At the same time, citizens of Hue were summoned by the Communist cadre to "political study" meetings at schools, churches, pagodas, and various public buildings where they were classified by categories -- civil servants, soldiers, police, ordinary citizens. Some were detained overnight after questioning, but most were allowed to return home.

Communist troops or NLF agents confiscated all radios in an effort to isolate the population from news of the outside world. At the same time, they spread the rumor that Thua Thien Province and all of South Viet-Nam had fallen to the forces of the National Liberation Front.^{13/}

During the first week of February, the Communist political cadre in charge of "exterminating tyrants" appeared to have seized on the idea that the Communist forces would occupy Hue for a protracted period. Their initial executions were calculated

^{13/} A graphic description of the Communists' behavior during their occupation of Hue is contained in The Viet Cong "Tet" Offensive (1968), Lt. Col. Pham Van Son, Senior Editor, published by the Military History Division of the Joint General Staff, Republic of Viet-Nam Armed Forces (RVNAF), Saigon, 1969, 490 pp. See the section headed "The Ancient Capital in Distress," pp. 271-84.

to "punish" certain key officials and to disrupt and "wear down" the governmental structure. Now, with the mistaken illusion that their forces might not be dislodged, the Liberation Army and its People's Revolutionary Party local auxiliaries extended the scope of their executions to encompass a much broader range of victims. Lower echelon civil servants, soldiers, policemen, teachers, students, shopkeepers, artisans, and ordinary laborers were called away from their homes to attend further "political indoctrination meetings" and were not seen again.

Examples of some of these victims are listed in a report prepared from cases in the files of the municipal police in Hue in March 1968 immediately following the expulsion of the Communist forces from the city and published by the 10th Political Warfare Battalion of the 1st Corps Tactical Zone of the Army of the Republic of Viet-Nam.^{14/}

^{14/} Vu Cuong-Sat cua Viet-Cong tai Co-Do Hue -- Mau Than 1968, Danang: Tieu Doan 10 CTCT, CD DTI, 1968, 21 pp. A revised and extended version of this report was published in English under the title Communist Carnage in Hue, Mau Than 1968 in April 1968, 37 pp.

Le Van Hoanh, age 35, mechanic, married, six children, residing in the hamlet of Duong Xuan Ha, on the outskirts of the city, was arrested at his house by the Viet Cong on February 6, 1968. His wife, crying, begged the VC to release him, but they refused, saying they were taking him to attend a political indoctrination meeting and he would come back soon. His body was found in a common grave with eight other victims in a school yard near Phu Bai, 14 kilometers southeast of Hue, on March 10.

Phan Dan Soan, 60, tailor, married, five children, residing in Chi Lang Street, Gia Hoi district of Hue, was obliged by the VC to dig graves and serve as a messenger. On February 12, 1968, declaring he was no longer of use to them, the VC seized him, bound his hands, and executed him with a bullet through the forehead. Soan's body was dumped into a hole with seven others in a field behind a pagoda, where it was found on March 10.

Ho Tan Sy, 18, teacher, married, one child, residing in Gia Hoi district, Hue. A VC group came to his house on the night of February 18 and invited him to attend a meeting. He was shot dead soon after he left his house. His wife heard the shot but did not believe it could be her husband "because he was only a teacher." She discovered his body fifty meters from the house the following

morning, arms tied, shot in the head.

Ngo Thong, 66, retired civil servant, married, seven children, residing at Chua Ong. Arrested by VC, he was later found arms bound, shot in the head, buried with ten other execution victims in a field on the north side of Hue.

Le Van Thang, 17, university student, residing in Gia Hoi district of Hue. Invited by VC to attend a political indoctrination meeting at the Gia Hoi High School on February 2. His body was found March 16 in a grave with two others in the yard of the school.

Miss Hoang Thi Tam Tuy, 26, a shopkeeper in the Dong Ba Market in downtown Hue, residing in To Hien Thanh Street, was arrested at six p. m. on February 22. She was condemned by the Viet Cong on unspecified charges and buried alive with four others in a common grave in the yard of the Gia Hoi High School.

Mrs. Duong Thi Co, 55, a widow with four children and an incense wood merchant, was arrested by the VC on the night of February 22, taken to Gia Hoi High School, condemned and shot on unspecified charges. Her body was found February 26.

Tran Dinh Trong, 20, a student at the Technical High School, residing at Mac Dinh Chi Street, had been married two months. He was summoned by the VC to a meeting at Gia Hoi High School

"to learn about politics." He did not return home. His body was found by his family with those of other execution victims in the yard of the school a month later.

The journalist Phu Si, writing in The Saigon Post on February 5, 1970, ^{15/} recounts the story of Tan Xuan An, a village schoolteacher, married and the father of three young children. He brought his family to visit his elderly father, a widower, and two teen-aged brothers who were living in a Buddhist neighborhood on the south side of Hue. They were all there together on the first night of Tet when the North Vietnamese and Viet Cong overran the city. The Viet Cong cadres went about during the first two or three days distributing National Liberation Front flags and ordering the people to display them in front of every third house. Then on the fourth day, the enemy ordered all civil servants and military personnel to surrender to them.

Mr. An's father advised his son not to surrender immediately but to wait and see. However, others who surrendered returned with the explanation that nothing much had happened. The VC agents had taken their identification cards and registered their names, organizations, positions, and addresses. Then they had issued them a "certificate of surrender" and allowed them

^{15/} "In Memory of Tet 1968," The Saigon Post, February 5, 1970, p. 4.

to return home. Reassured by this, Mr. An reported to the VC who questioned him, took his identification card, and allowed him also to go home.

Eight days later two Viet Cong soldiers appeared at the door of the house and informed Mr. An that he must leave immediately "for five days of indoctrination training." He was told that he should bring along food to cover this period.

"So," recalls Phu Si, who knows the family well, "Mr. Duc [An's father] took a bag, poured in 15 liters of rice, some dry food, a few garments, a blanket and a mosquito net along with 300 piasters. The family bade An good luck and a speedy return.

"That was the last anyone saw of him."

Eighteen months later the skeletal remains of the young schoolmaster were found with those of hundreds of other victims who had been shot and left lying in and beside a remote, jungle-canopied creek bed in the mountains 16 kilometers south of Hue.

The identity was established when the elderly father, who with other members of the family had been searching for a year and a half for some trace of his lost son, recognized the ragged remains of a shirt An had been wearing when the two Viet Cong came and led him away.

"Mr. Duc remembered the shirt well for it was one of three

sportshirts An's wife had given him for his 28th birthday," writes Pha Si. "He also discovered An's string of beads with a small medallion of the Buddha."

In many instances citizens of Hue were required to dig their own graves. "Survivors and enemy agents, captured in the later stages of the Hue battle, recounted that the victims had been told to dig air raid trenches during the daytime. Then they were actually led to these so-called trenches in the night to be massacred by submachinegun fire or simply buried alive. Apparently the victims had never suspected they were digging their own mass graves. In many cases the victims were murdered and shoved into the graves soon after they had finished digging." 16/

In what was evidently intended to become a systematic purge of "social negatives" -- that is, any individual or class that might inhibit the achievement of Communist objectives or who lacked sympathy for the revolution -- entire elements of the population were selected for extermination.

On February 5, 1968, a Communist political cell leader, accompanied by members of a special action unit, entered the Hue Cathedral, which lies in the predominantly Catholic section of the

16/ The Viet Cong "Tet" Offensive (1968), p. 276.

city south of the Phu Can River, and ordered out 398 men and boys from among the refugees gathered there for safety from the fighting. Some were selected by name, others apparently because of their appearance, i.e., prosperous looking and well-dressed. These unfortunate people, as in the case of so many others, were told they were going to a "liberated area" for three days of indoctrination after which they could return home. They were marched off to the south and not seen again.

The skeletal remains of most of these and others picked up by Viet Cong in the neighboring Tu Dam section were found last September -- a year and a half after their disappearance -- in the same jungle-covered creek bed where the Buddhist schoolmaster An met his death.

The Communist Party was "particularly anxious to get those people at Phu Cam...." Ho Ty, Party secretary for a sector of Hue City who was captured September 4, 1969, shortly before the remains of the victims were found, told a reporter later in an interview. "The Catholics were considered particular enemies of ours." 17/

17/ Don Oberdorfer, "Hue: Deliberate Slaughter," The Washington Post, December 7, 1969.

Three days later, on February 8, a similar incident occurred at the great Redemptorist Church, about a kilometer east of the Cathedral. More than 4,000 persons were sheltered in this church, including Senator Tran Dien, one of the City of Hue's five selected Senators in the National Assembly in Saigon, and his wife and ten children. People's Revolutionary Party political agents, including female cadre, entered the church with rosters of names of people in certain categories and selected Senator Dien and 80-100 others from among the refugees. The 55-year-old Senator and the others were taken away despite the tearful pleadings of their families. His body and those of nineteen others of this group, including two women, were found with arms bound in four collective graves in a rice paddy near the village of Lang Xa Con, three kilometers east of the city, two months later. All had been shot.

Members of the West German medical mission to the University of Hue were executed. Dr. Horst Krainick, 59, professor of pediatrics and his wife, Elisabeth, a trained medical technician, together with their colleagues, Dr. Raimund Discher, 44, professor of internal medicine, and Dr. Alois Altekoeester, 36, professor of general medicine, were taken from their apartments near the Medical Faculty on February 5 and escorted away by Viet Cong political cadre. Their bodies were found in a single shallow grave

in a potato field behind a rural pagoda two kilometers south of Hue on April 2. All had been shot in the back of the head and their hands bound behind them with wire.

Stephen Miller, 27, an American foreign service officer working with the American civil affairs group in Hue, was seized at his house by members of a Viet Cong action squad on February 5, escorted at pistol point to a nearby Catholic Seminary, and beaten to death in one of the classrooms along with four Vietnamese civilians. The bodies of the young American (a Quaker, married, and the father of three small children) and the four Vietnamese civilians were recovered later by priests and buried in the yard of the Seminary.

Another American, Courtney Niles, 36, a technical advisor at the Hue television station, was wounded as he fled his house. He attempted, despite his wounds, to escape across a neighboring rice field, but was followed by the Viet Cong and shot to death.

Six other American civilians from the civil affairs advisory group were killed, and three captured and taken away. The body of one of the captured, Thomas W. Ragsdale, a young agricultural specialist, was found in a shallow grave in the A Shau Valley some sixty kilometers southwest of Hue in July 1969.^{13/}

^{13/} United States Mission in Viet-Nam, Press Release No. 70 of August 6, 1969.